

THE ROUND — EVERYONE TAKES ONE TURN

1 INITIATIVE LEADS

The player with the **initiative marker** plays the **lead card** — or **passes initiative** clockwise to the next player with cards, ending the round.

2 OTHERS FOLLOW

Each other player, in clockwise order, takes a turn: **Surpass**, **Copy**, or **Pivot**. No cards in hand? Skip.

3 CHECK INITIATIVE

If someone **seized**, they keep it. Otherwise it goes to the **highest Surpass**. Nobody Surpassed? It stays put.

4 DISCARD & REPEAT

Discard all played cards face down. Hands empty (or everyone with cards passed)? The **chapter ends** — **score ambitions** (see back).

YOUR TURN — FOUR STEPS, IN ORDER

1 PLAY ONE CARD

As **lead** if you hold initiative — otherwise **Surpass**, **Copy**, or **Pivot** (1 below).

2 DECLARE / SEIZE

Optional. The initiative player may **declare an ambition**; others may **seize the initiative** (2 below).

3 PRELUDE

Spend any number of **resources** and “**Prelude:**” card actions (3 below).

4 TAKE ACTIONS

One action per pip, matching your card's suit (4 below). Your first pip ends the Prelude.

1 PLAY YOUR CARD — FOUR WAYS



LEAD INITIATIVE PLAYER — ALL PIPS ♦♦♦♦

Play any card face up as the **lead card**. Take up to **one action per pip** in its corner. Its suit sets the round's **lead suit**.



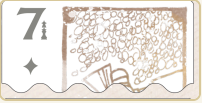
SURPASS — ALL PIPS

Face up, **same suit as the lead card**, **higher number** than the lead card (*not than every card!*). Take up to **one action per pip on your card**.



COPY — 1 ACTION

Any card, **face down**. Take **one action of the lead card**. Can't Surpass or Pivot? You can always Copy.



PIVOT — 1 ACTION

Face up, any card **not of the lead suit**. Take **one action on your card** (*not the lead card's!*). Doesn't change the lead suit.

2 DECLARE OR SEIZE

Declare — only the **initiative player**, when playing the lead card, before Prelude & actions: cover the card's number with the **zero marker** (it becomes **0**, pips unchanged — easy to Surpass, so you'll likely lose initiative) and put the **highest available ambition marker** in the matching box. The card's **number** picks the ambition:

2 Tycoon · 3 Tyrant · 4 Warlord · 5 Keeper · 6 Empath · 7 any · 1 none

You may re-declare an already-declared ambition (stack another marker). No markers left? No declaring. (“1” and “7” cards are used in 4-player games only.)

Seize — any **other player**, when playing their card, if no one has seized yet this round: play an **extra card face down** (no actions from it), or Surpass with a 7 (4-player). Lay the marker on its side. Whoever seized keeps initiative at round's end.

INITIATIVE



Whoever holds the marker leads the next round — going **first is power**, but leading spends your good cards.

Passing: with initiative and no card you want to play, pass it clockwise (to the next player holding cards) — the round ends immediately.

3 PRELUDE — WHAT RESOURCES DO



Material — take a **Build** or **Repair** action.



Fuel — take a **Move** action.



Weapon — this turn, your card's pips may also be spent on **Battle** actions.



Relic — take a **Secure** action.



Psionic — take any action listed on the **lead card**.

Spent resources return to the supply only **after** your Prelude ends, and cards secured this Prelude can't be used yet.

Outrage: Outraged resources cannot be spent for their Prelude action — they still count for ambitions and can still be taxed. You also can't spend resources if you pass initiative or have no cards in hand.

4 TAKE ACTIONS • GLOSSARY

♦ **ADMINISTRATION** Tax · Repair · Influence

♦ **AGGRESSION** Battle · Move · Secure

♦ **CONSTRUCTION** Build · Repair

♦ **MOBILIZATION** Move · Influence

Tax — pick a Loyal city, or a Rival city *you control*: gain 1 resource of its planet type. Rival city: also capture 1 of their agents. Once per city per turn.

Move — any number of Loyal ships, one system » one adjacent system. From a Loyal starport: **Catapult** — keep moving until entering any planet or a gate a Rival controls.

Influence — place 1 agent on any card in the Court.

Battle — fight in one system (*full workflow on back*).

Build — place a city/starport in an empty slot on a planet with Loyal pieces, or 1 ship at a Loyal starport (1 ship per starport per turn). Built where a Rival controls? It arrives damaged.

Repair — flip or stand up 1 damaged Loyal piece, anywhere on the map.

Secure — take a Court card where you have *more* agents than each Rival. Your agents return; Rival agents become **Captives**. Refill the Court.

BATTLE — AN AGGRESSION ACTION

THE BATTLE DICE — ALL SIX FACES

1 CHOOSE BATTLE SYSTEM

Any one system with your **Loyal** ships — they are your **attackers**.

2 CHOOSE DEFENDER

One **Rival** with pieces there. All their pieces in the system defend.

3 COLLECT DICE — UP TO 1 PER ATTACKING SHIP

Mix freely; max 6 of a type; you may take fewer. **Assault** hits fast but singes you. **Skirmish** is slow and safe. **Raid** steals and cracks buildings — riskiest.

Raid limit: raid dice only if the defender has buildings here — or no Loyal buildings anywhere on the map.

4 ROLL — RESOLVE EVERY FACE, IN THIS ORDER

- 1 • Hit your own ships — once per flame rolled.
- 2 • Intercept — if any rings rolled: hit your ships once per fresh defending ship. Happens at most once per battle.
- 3 • Hit defending ships — once per burst. No defending ships left? Hit their buildings instead.
- 4 • Hit defending buildings — once per building-burst.
- 5 • Raid — only if you still have attacking ships: spend keys to steal the defender's resources & Guild cards, paying each item's raid cost in keys.

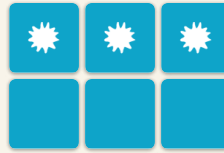
The **attacker** makes every choice — the defender just watches.

ASSAULT



Heavy damage, self-hits, one intercept face

SKIRMISH



Half hit, half nothing — never hurts you

RAID



Keys & building hits — but self-hits and intercepts



Hit a defending ship (then buildings)



Hit building — a defending building



Key — spend to steal (raid cost)



Self-hit — hit your own attacking ship



Intercept — defender strikes back once



Pip — one action from a played card

THE FIVE AMBITIONS

2



TYCOON

Most **Material** + **Fuel** icons on your resources & Guild cards

3



TYRANT

Most **Captives** — from taxing Rival cities & securing cards with Rival agents (*returned after scoring*)

4



WARLORD

Most **Trophies** — Rival pieces you destroyed (*returned after scoring*)

5



KEEPER

Most **Relic** icons on your resources & Guild cards

6



EMPATH

Most **Psionic** icons on your resources & Guild cards

Weapon resources & Weapon Guild cards feed no ambition — they're for fighting.

RESOLVING A BATTLE & TRIGGERING OUTRAGE

fresh » **damaged** » **destroyed**. A hit damages a fresh piece (tip ship / flip building) and **destroys** a damaged one.

Trophies: destroyed pieces land in a **Trophies box** — the attacker takes the defender's destroyed pieces, the defender takes the attacker's. Trophies feed Warlord.

Destroying a city (even outside battle):

- 1 • **Provoke Outrage** — discard all your resources & Guild cards of that city's planet type; an agent covers that Outrage slot. That resource type loses its Prelude action for the rest of the game.
- 2 • **Ransack the Court** — immediately Secure any Court card holding the defender's agents (any number). Rival agents there become **Trophies**, not **Captives**.

PIECES & TERMS



Ship — moves, battles, and controls systems.



Starport — builds ships; launches Catapult moves.



Initiative marker — its holder leads the round; laid on its side when seized.



City — tax it for resources; opens resource slots & scoring bonuses.



Agent — influence in the Court; can be captured.



Ambition marker — marks a declared ambition and the Power it awards.

Loyal — a piece of your color. **Rival** — another player, or a piece of their color.

Fresh — upright ship, or building on its bright side. **Damaged** — tipped ship, or building on its dark side. Hitting a damaged piece **destroys** it.

System — a planet or a gate. Systems sharing a thin border are **adjacent**.

Capture — take a Rival piece to your Captives box (*feeds Tyrant*).

Control — more **fresh** ships in the system than each Rival. On a tie, no one controls.

Building — a city or a starport.

Gate — the numbered hub system of each 3-planet cluster. It is adjacent to its cluster's planets *and* to the neighboring clusters' gates, so travel between clusters flows through gates. Gates have no building slots.

Trophy — a destroyed piece: the attacker takes the defender's destroyed pieces and vice versa (*feeds Warlord*).

CHAPTER END — SCORING & VICTORY

Score each declared ambition: 1st place gains the large number on every marker in its box; 2nd place gains the small. You must have **at least one** of what it counts.

Ties: tied for 1st » each tied player takes **2nd place** Power, 1st goes unawarded, and **everyone else scores nothing** — 2nd is used up. Tied for 2nd » those tied score nothing.

City bonus: each untied 1st gains +2 if your "+2" city slot is open (+5 if "+3" is open too).

Then return markers (and scored Trophies/Captives), and everyone draws a new hand of **6 cards**. **Game ends** at chapter end if anyone has **27 Power** (4p) / **30** (3p) / **33** (2p) — or after **Chapter 5**. Most Power wins; ties go to the tied player earliest in turn order.



each chapter, lowest unflipped marker flips

THE COURT & GUILD CARDS



Influence puts agents on Court cards; **Secure** takes one where you have the most. **Guild cards** join your play area — their **suit icon** counts toward ambitions exactly like a resource, and their **raid cost** is the keys needed to steal them in battle. **Vox cards** resolve immediately when secured.

LEADERS & LORE

Your **Leader** grants unique powers all game. **Lore** cards grant persistent powers — no suit icon or raid cost, so they never add to ambitions and can't be stolen. **Card text beats the rulebook**; only "cannot" is absolute. New actions like "Summon (*Build*)" may replace the named action whenever you could take it.